

Representation on Continuous Policies

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Argument

- To understand representation, we need to consider policy in a continuous space
- We also need to measure intensity over that space

Evidence

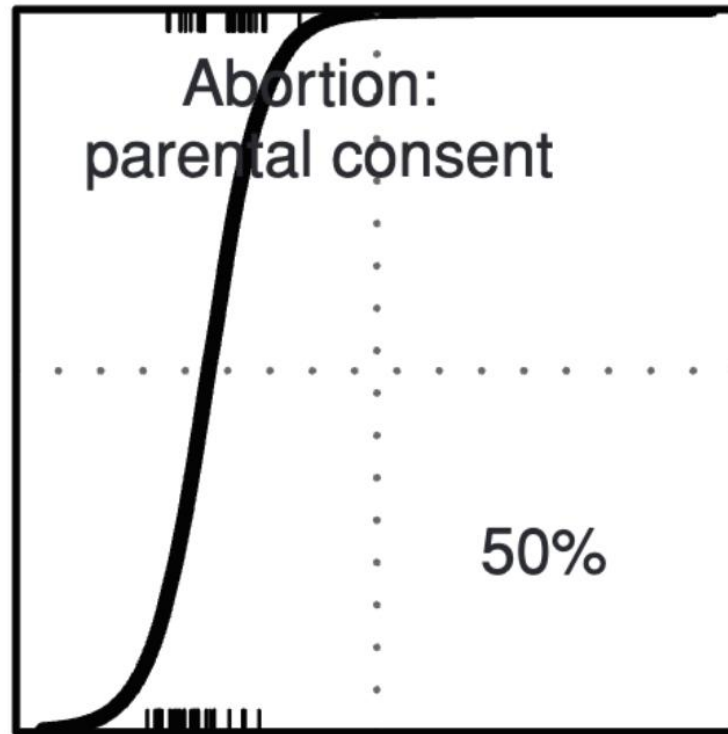
- I attempt this in the case of the minimum wage
- My measures tell a different story than standard “congruence”

Policy incongruence is pervasive

- Congruence = Policy aligns with public opinion majority
- Policy in the states is congruent 60% of the time (Caughey and Warshaw 2022)
- Lawmaking in Congress is congruent 55% of the time (Ansolabehere and Kuriwaki 2025)
 - Passes unpopular bills 38% of the time
 - Fails to pass popular bills 47% of the time

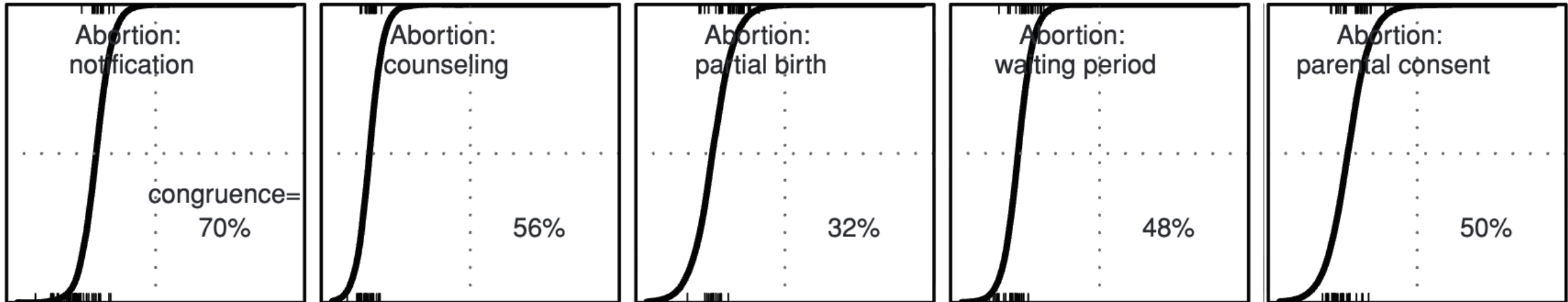
Measured congruence = almost always binary

- Either a state has parental consent requirements for abortion or they don't.



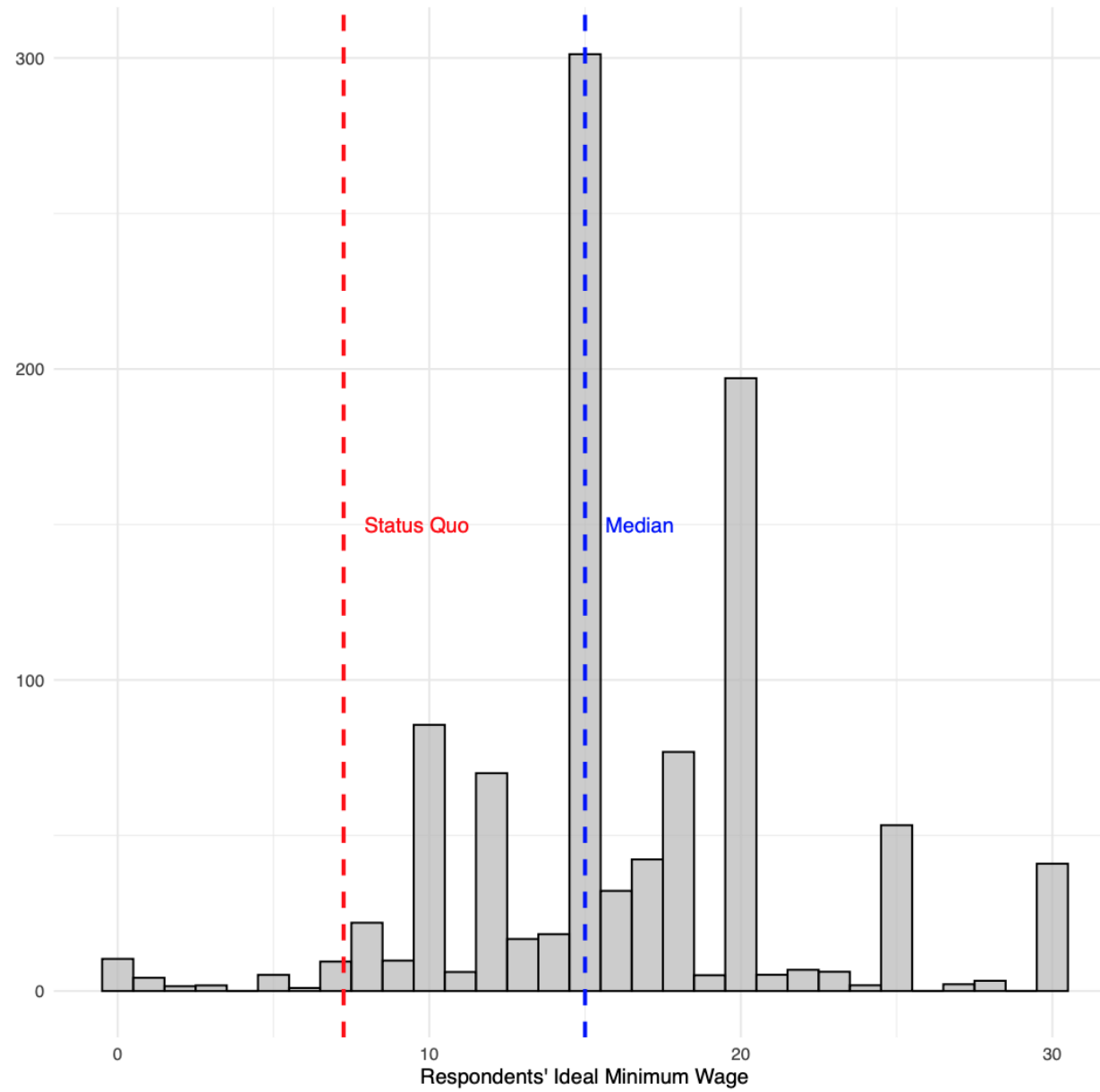
Lax and Phillips (2012)

But policy is continuous

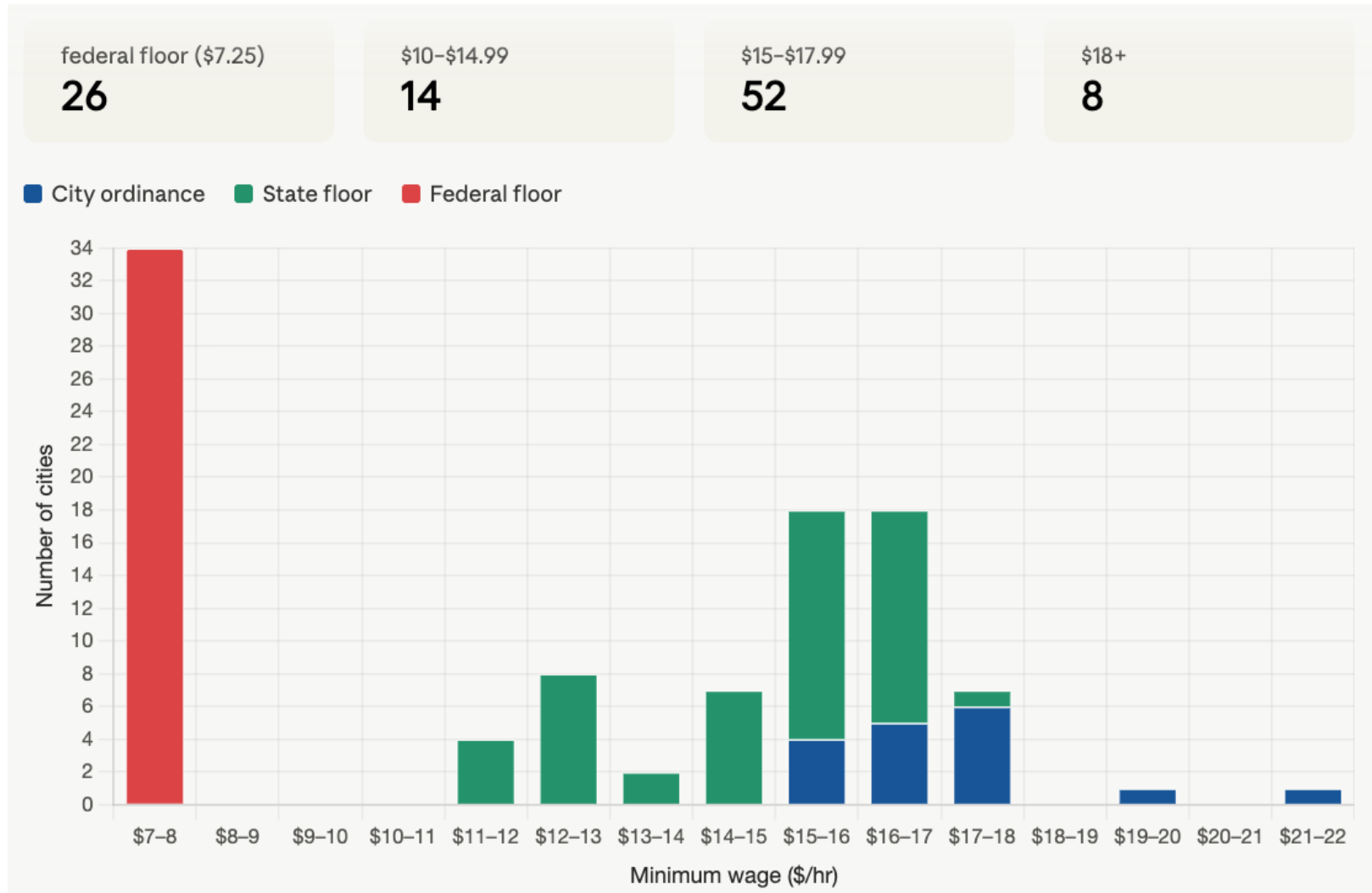


Congruence in continuous space is never perfect

- Continuous congruence = distance between policy and median preference
- Simonovitz and Payson (2023) find that state minimum wages are \$2 less than voters prefer, on average
- Is this a lot or a little?
- Empirical question: what should we expect?



City-level minimum wages (100 largest cities)



How much incongruence should we expect?

- In the simple two candidate spatial voting model: none
- *But IF*
 - There are aggregate shocks to relative preference for candidates
 - Candidates are office-motivated *and* policy-motivated
- **THEN**
 - The extent of policy incongruence may depend on the intensity of voter preferences

Measuring the elasticity of choice

- Politicians need to know how their positions affect vote decisions
- Measuring the elasticity of vote decisions:
 - We offer people bundles of policy positions that we vary experimentally
 - Estimate the effect of positions on choice
- We include policy of current federal minimum wage (\$7.25) and minimum wages varying from \$0 to \$30 in \$1 increments.
- Each respondent (N=1,050) reports their views on 10 binary issues + continuous minimum wage, and responds to 10 experiments

Experiment For Measuring Elasticity

- Choice of one of two sets of policies, A or B
- Four policies: Minimum wage plus 3 others randomly selected from list of 10, order randomized
- For policies other than the minimum wage, affirmative version assigned to one set and negative version assigned to other
- For minimum wage, \$7.25 assigned to one set, \$0 to \$30 randomly chosen for the other

Given this choice, which one would you prefer?

Set A	Set B
Permit abortion	Never permit abortion
Legalize marijuana nationwide	Do not legalize marijuana nationwide
Raise the federal minimum wage to \$23 per hour	Keep the federal minimum wage at \$7.25 per hour
Do not ban assault rifles	Ban assault rifles

☐ Set A

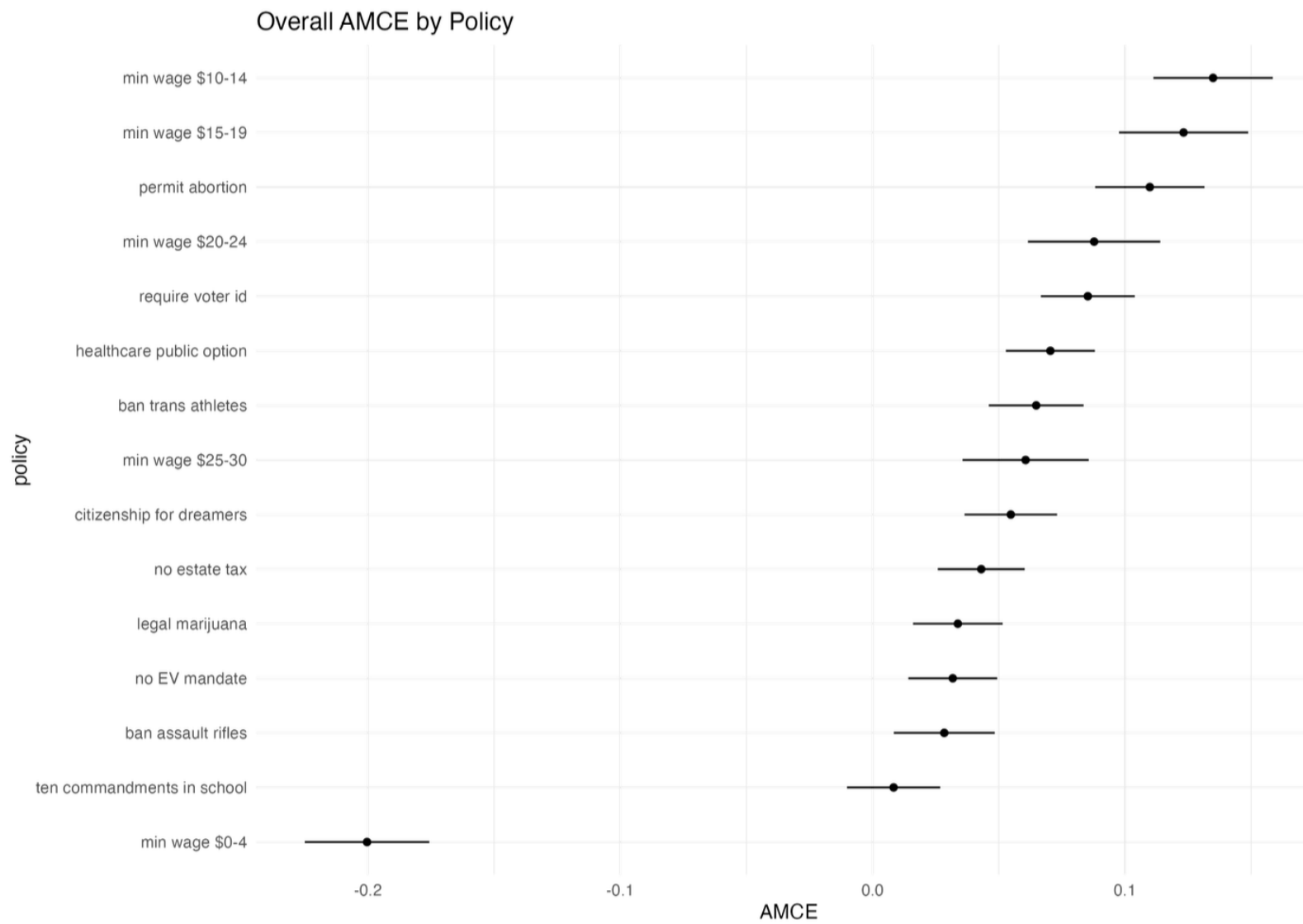
☐ Set B

Table 1: List of policy attributes besides the minimum wage

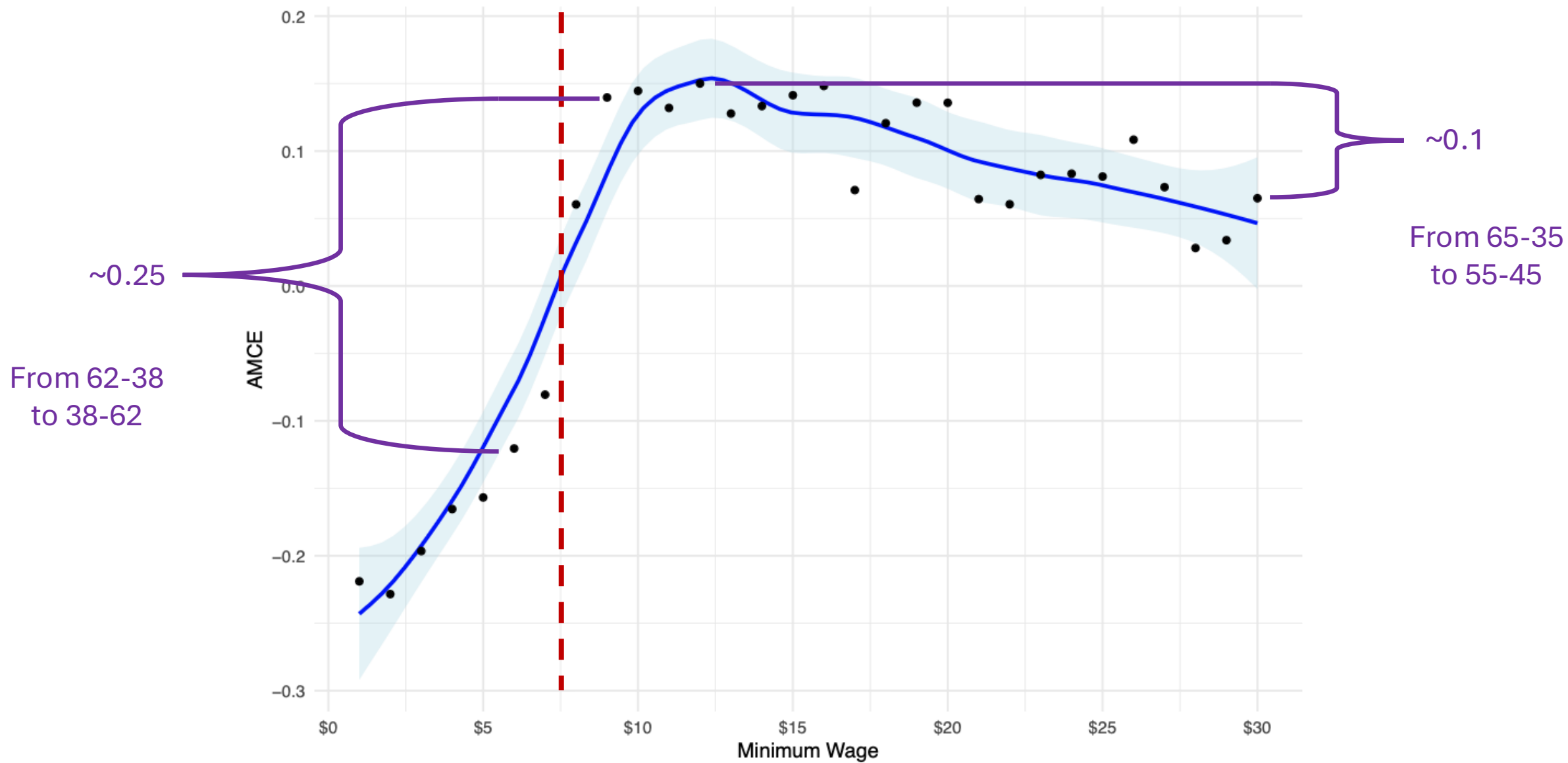
Affirmative	Negative
Permit abortion	Never permit abortion
Ban assault rifles	Do not ban assault rifles
Create a path to citizenship for undocumented immigrants brought here as children	Do not create a path to citizenship for undocumented immigrants brought here as children
Prohibit transgender people from competing in womens' and girls' sports	Do not prohibit transgender people from competing in womens' and girls' sports
Eliminate a rule that mandates that electric vehicles be at least half of all new cars and trucks sold in the United States by 2032	Keep a rule that mandates that electric vehicles be at least half of all new cars and trucks sold in the United States by 2032
Require people to provide documentary proof of citizenship in order to vote	Do not require people to provide documentary proof of citizenship in order to vote
Allow the display of the Ten Commandments in public schools and courthouses	Do not allow the display of the Ten Commandments in public schools and courthouses
Provide the option to purchase government-run insurance to all Americans	Do not provide the option to purchase government-run insurance to all Americans
Eliminate the estate tax	Keep the estate tax
Legalize marijuana nationwide	Do not legalize marijuana nationwide

The Average Marginal Component Effect

- This is just the regression coefficient of a 1,0,-1 dummy variable on choice of Set A
- 1 = affirmative version of the policy appears in set A
 - For minimum wage, values ranging from \$0 to \$30
- -1 = negative version appears in set A
 - For minimum wage, \$7.25
- 0 = policy does not appear in either set
 - For minimum wage, *that specific comparison*
- All effects estimated in one multiple regression, standard errors clustered by respondent



Overall AMCE for Every Minimum Wage



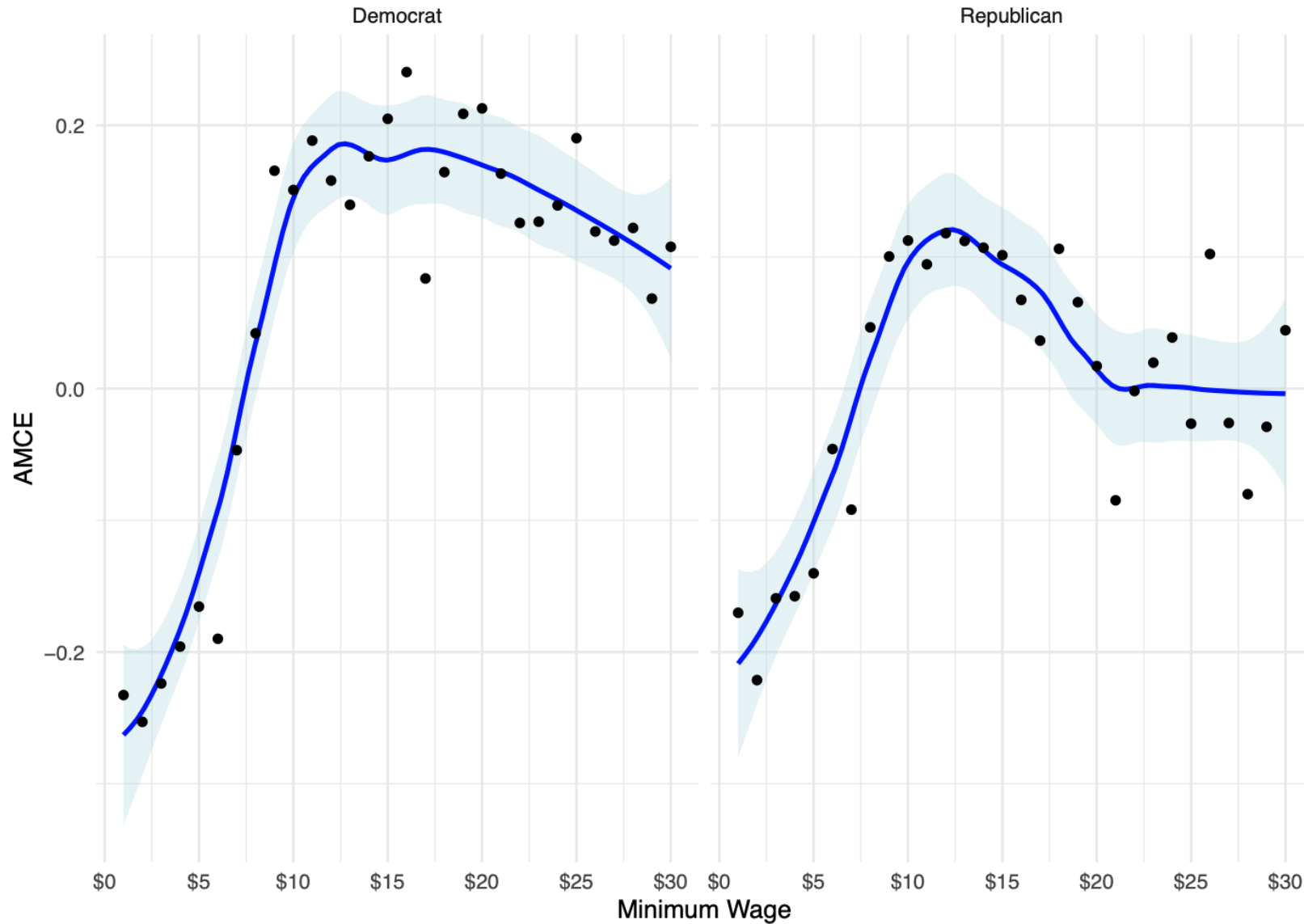
Indifference zone

- Choices of alternatives to the status quo from \$0 to \$9 make a large difference in choice probabilities
 - Roughly .044 change in AMCE per \$1
- Choices of alternatives from \$10 to \$30 have about a tenth of the effect
 - Roughly .005 change in AMCE per \$1

What are the political implications?

- Overshooting preferred minimum wage is much less consequential for votes than undershooting
- Is \$10 a failure of democracy? \$30?
- Some forms of “incongruence” much more consequential!
- Elections in the US are two-stage: what about the primary?

Overall AMCE for Every Minimum Wage



Reality check

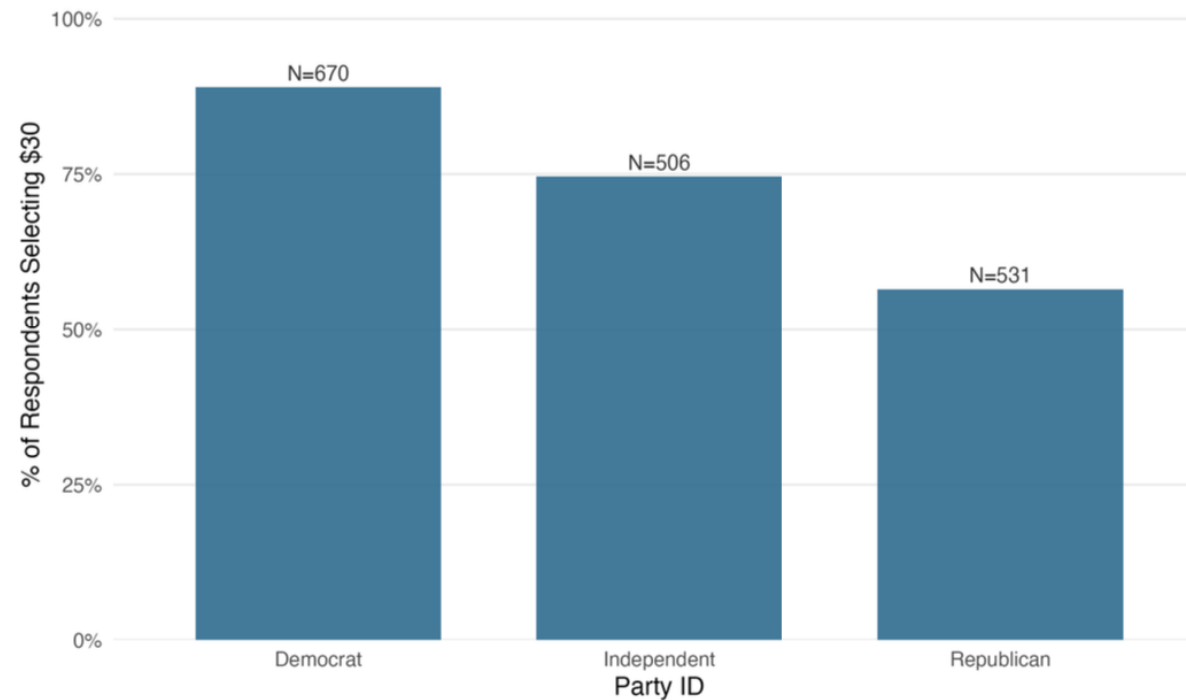
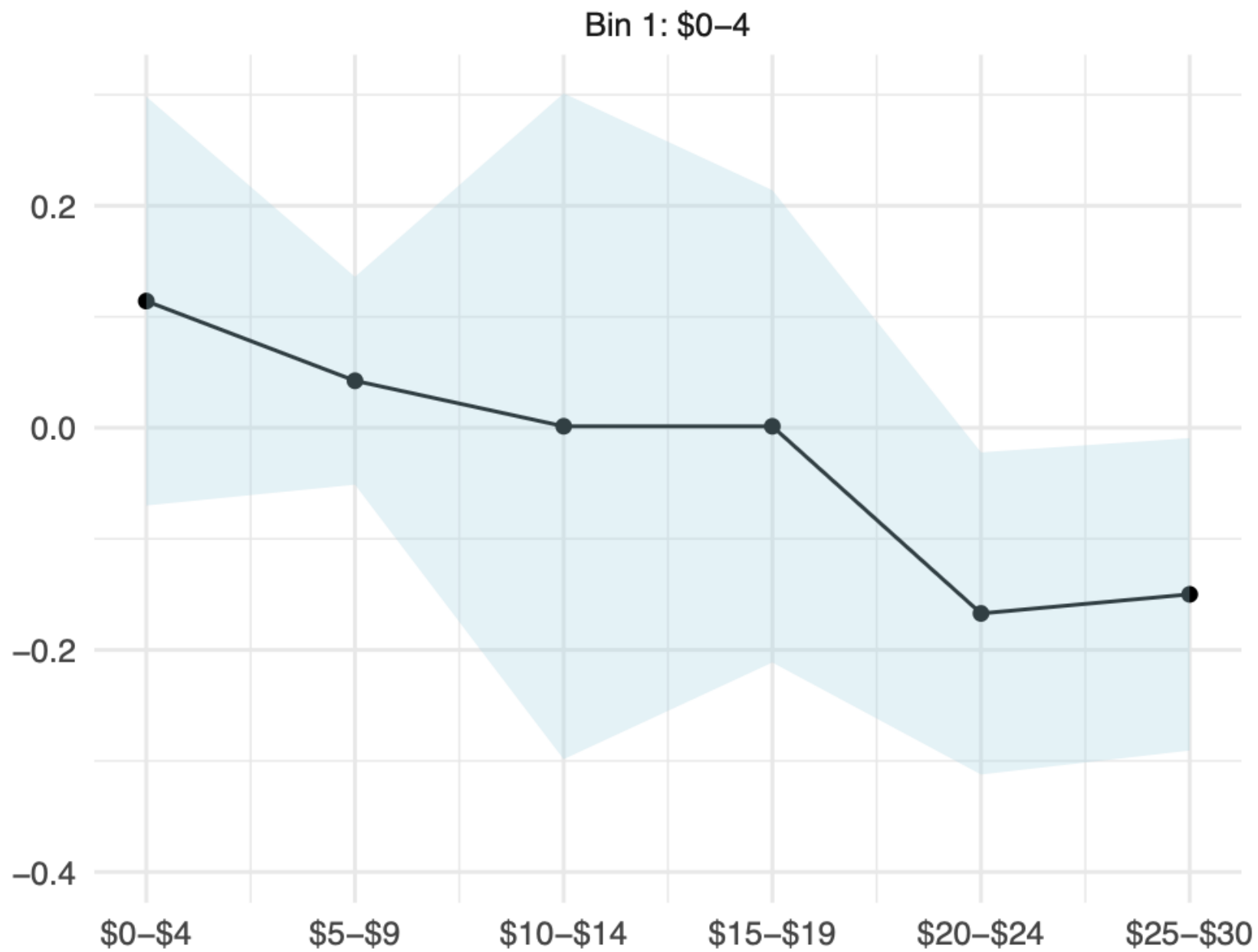


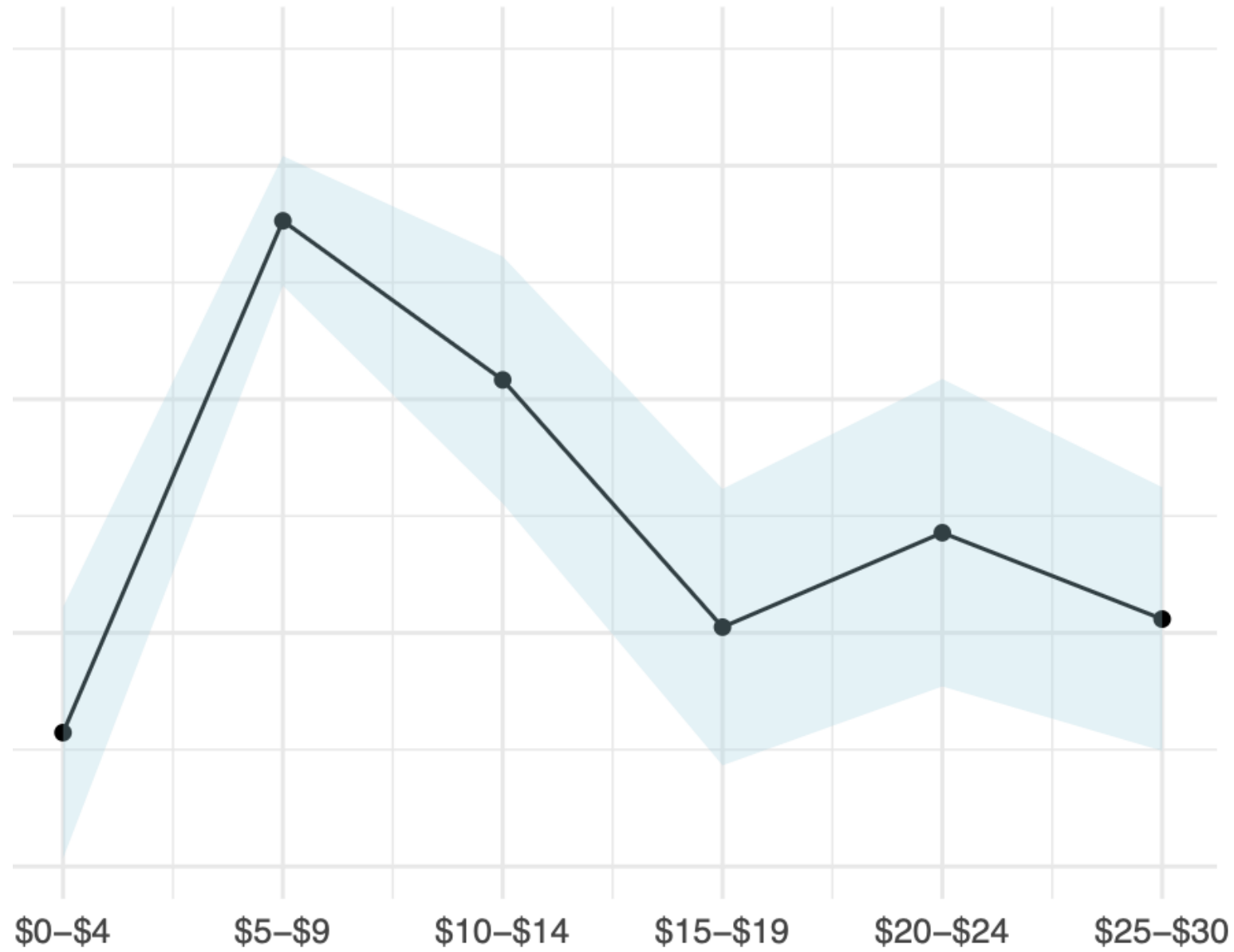
Figure 8: Percentage of respondents who select a \$30 minimum wage over a \$5 minimum wage in a direct comparison, broken down by respondents' partisan identification.

Who accounts for the elasticity

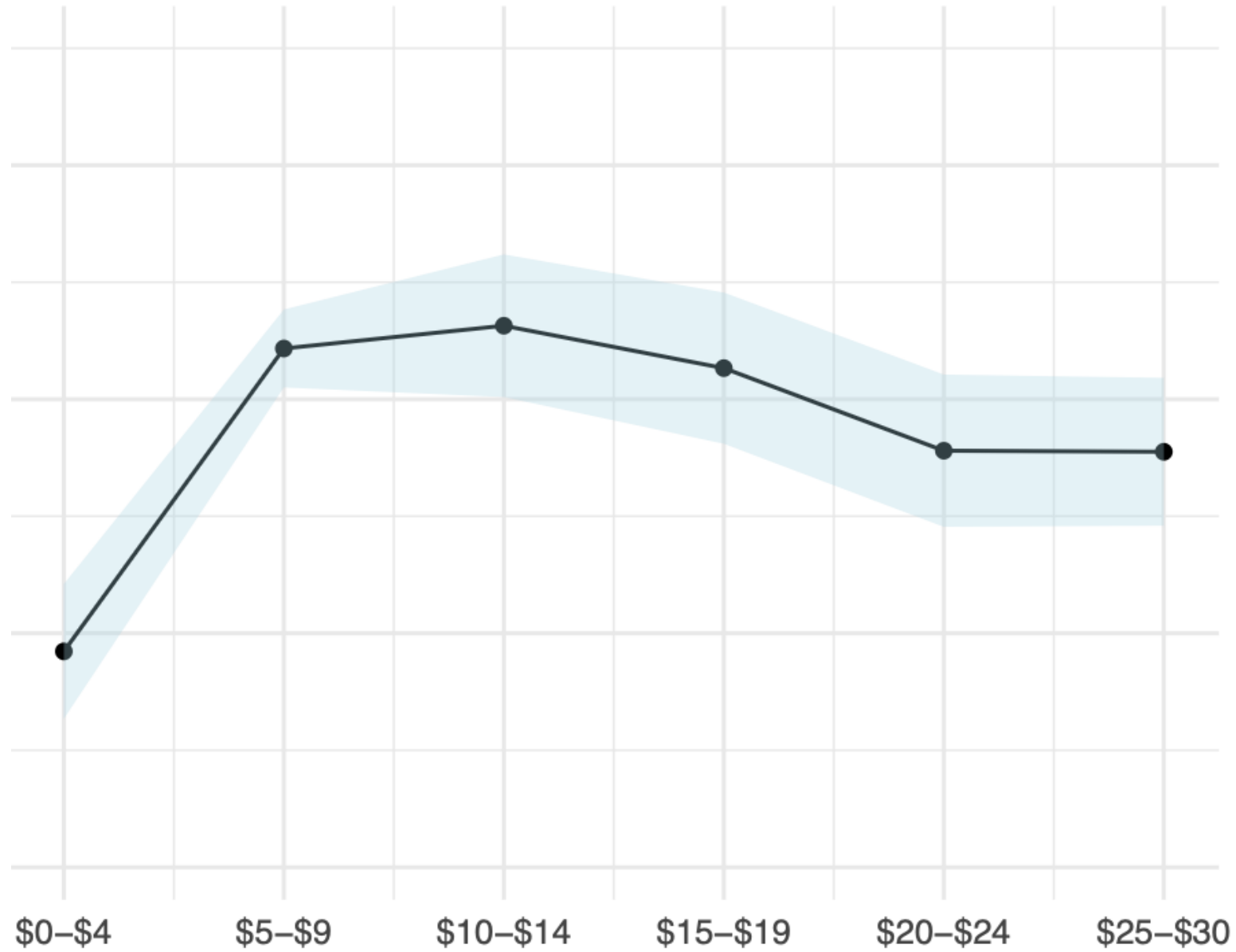
- “Churn” could be politically consequential
- High individual elasticities could motivate more intensive forms of participation (e.g. issue publics)
- But individual-level is hard to obtain
- However, we can look at elasticity by most-preferred minimum wage
 - Indifference is widespread for large majority favoring increases



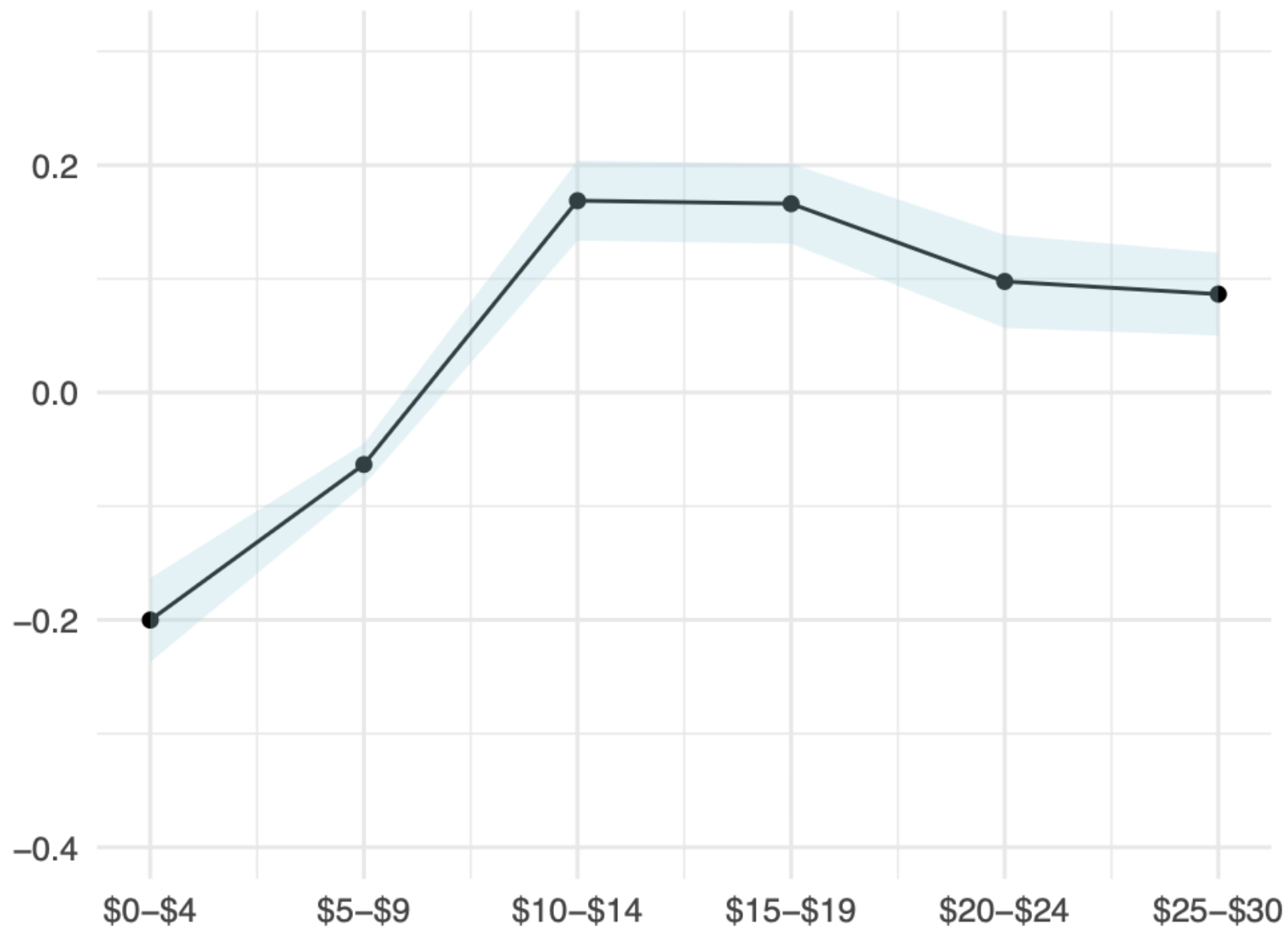
Bin 2: \$5–9



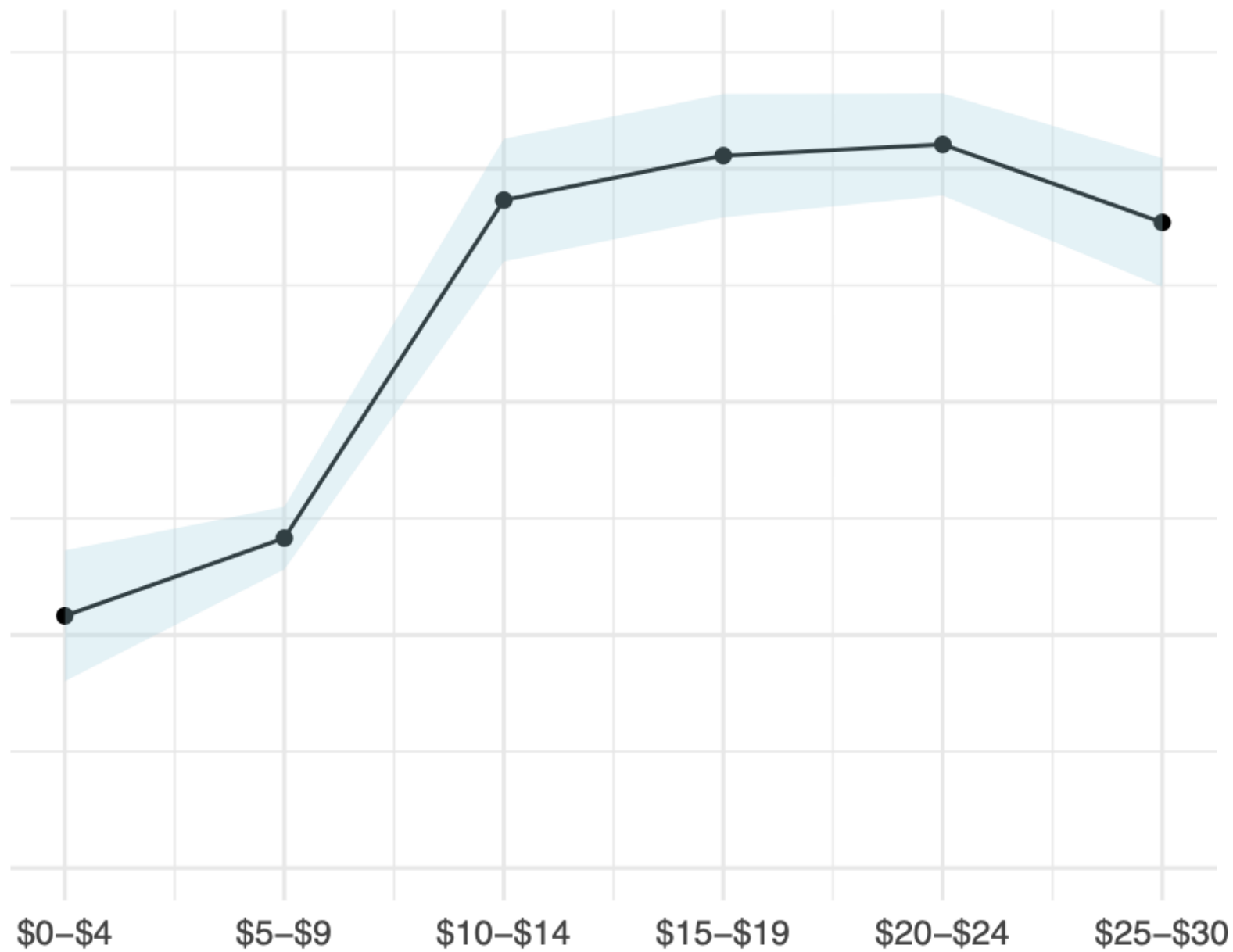
Bin 3: \$10–14



Bin 4: \$15–19

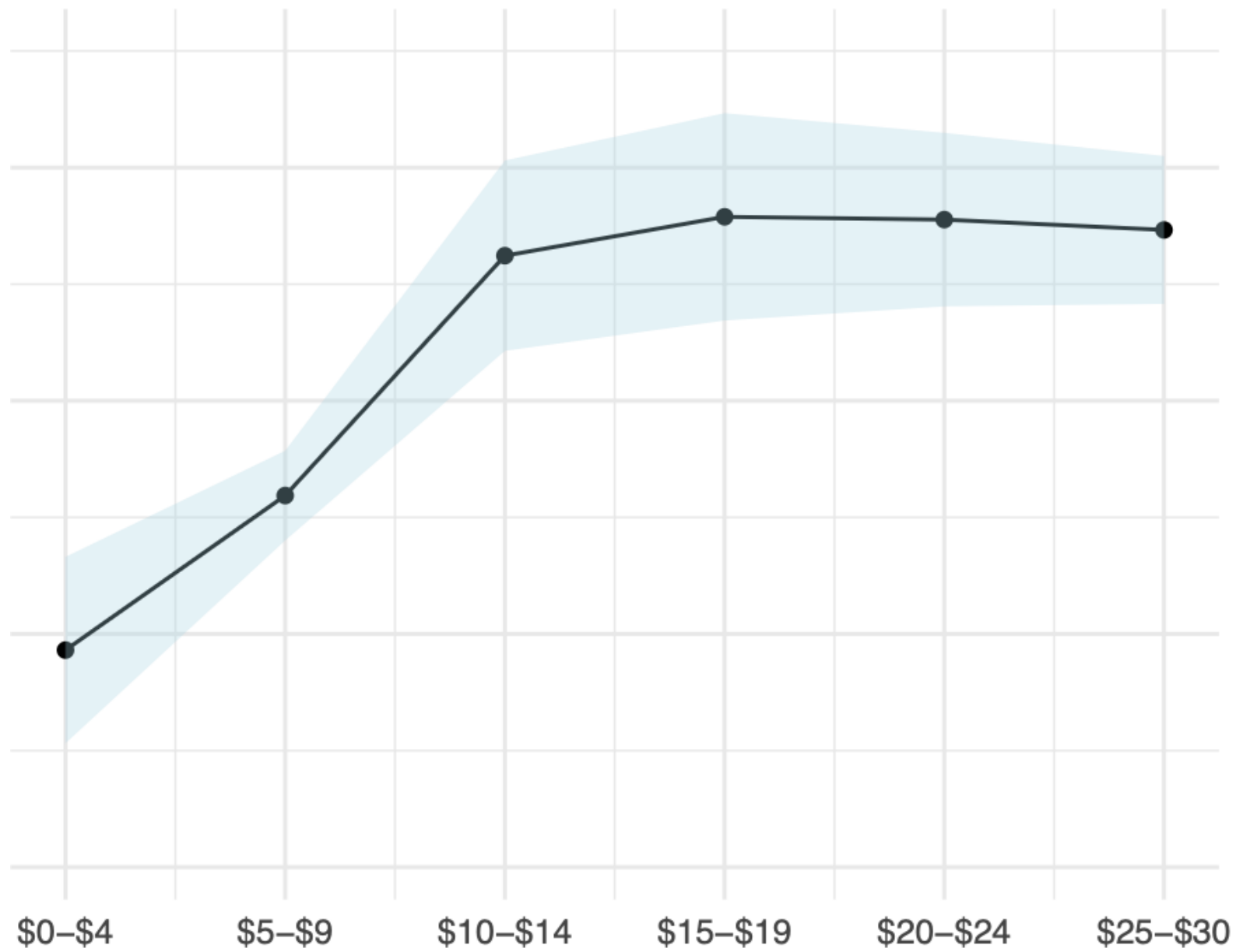


Bin 5: \$20–24

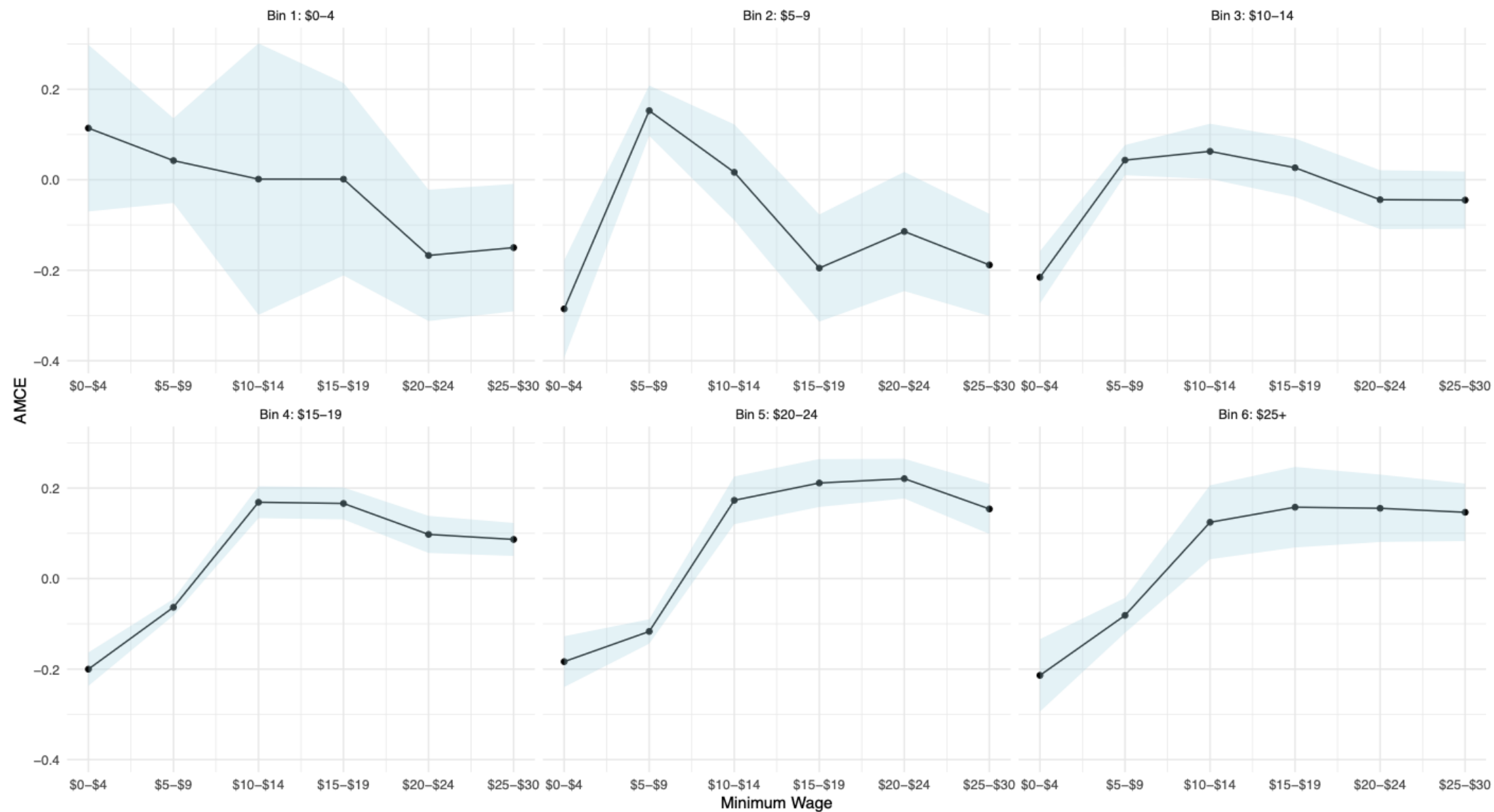


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Bin 6: \$25+



Experimental Bin AMCE by Ideal Point Bin



Representation on Continuous Policies

Summary: Findings

- The public is close-to-indifferent over a wide range of values of the minimum wage
- A priori, we should not expect politicians to lose substantial vote share from deviating from the most preferred minimum wage (\$15)
- With the exception that the public has an intense preference for higher-than-federal minimum wages

Takeaways

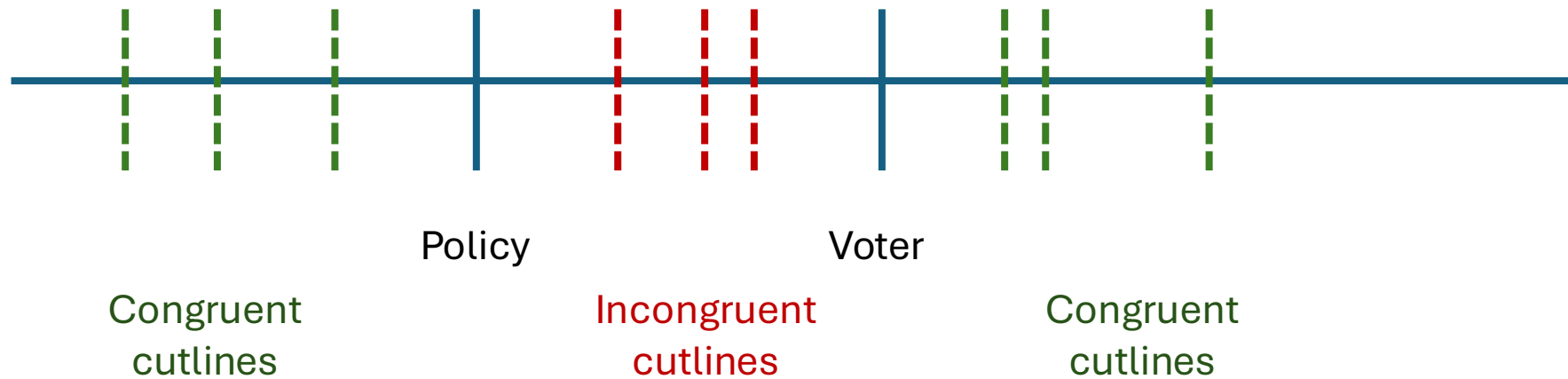
- Almost all policies exist in a continuum of policy options
- Our expectations about representation depend on our theory of accountability
- If candidates are policy motivated and voting is probabilistic, then the elasticity of choice of the public over a continuum of options is fundamental in shaping electoral incentives
- Ambivalence does not explain *all* gaps in representation – more research needed

Extra Slides

Variable	Unweighted Proportion	Weighted Proportion	2023 ACS Proportion
Gender			
Male	50.5%	50.5%	49.5%
Female	49.1%	49%	50.5%
Other	0.4%	0.4%	NA
Education			
HS or less	35.3%	36.4%	36.1%
Some college/2-yr degree	26.3%	26%	27.7%
4-yr/post-graduate degree	38.4%	37.5%	36.2%
Age			
18-29	16.6%	19.7%	16.5%
30-44	25.3%	25.9%	24.1%
45-64	33.1%	31%	33.4%
65+	24.7%	23.1%	26%
Race			
White	61%	60.3%	59.3%
Black	12.5%	12.2%	13.6%
Hispanic	16.4%	17%	18.9%
Other	10.1%	10.5%	2.1%
2024 Vote			
Donald Trump	39.6%	40%	
Kamala Harris	40.7%	38.4%	
Someone else:	2.3%	2.5%	
I abstained	0.9%	0.9%	
I don't recall	0.5%	0.5%	
Party			
Democrat	34%	30.9%	
Republican	36.1%	35.7%	
Independent	26%	29%	
Something else	3.7%	4.1%	

Table A1: Characteristics of the sample, both weighted and unweighted, compared to the 2023 American Community Survey.

Congruence depends on item selection



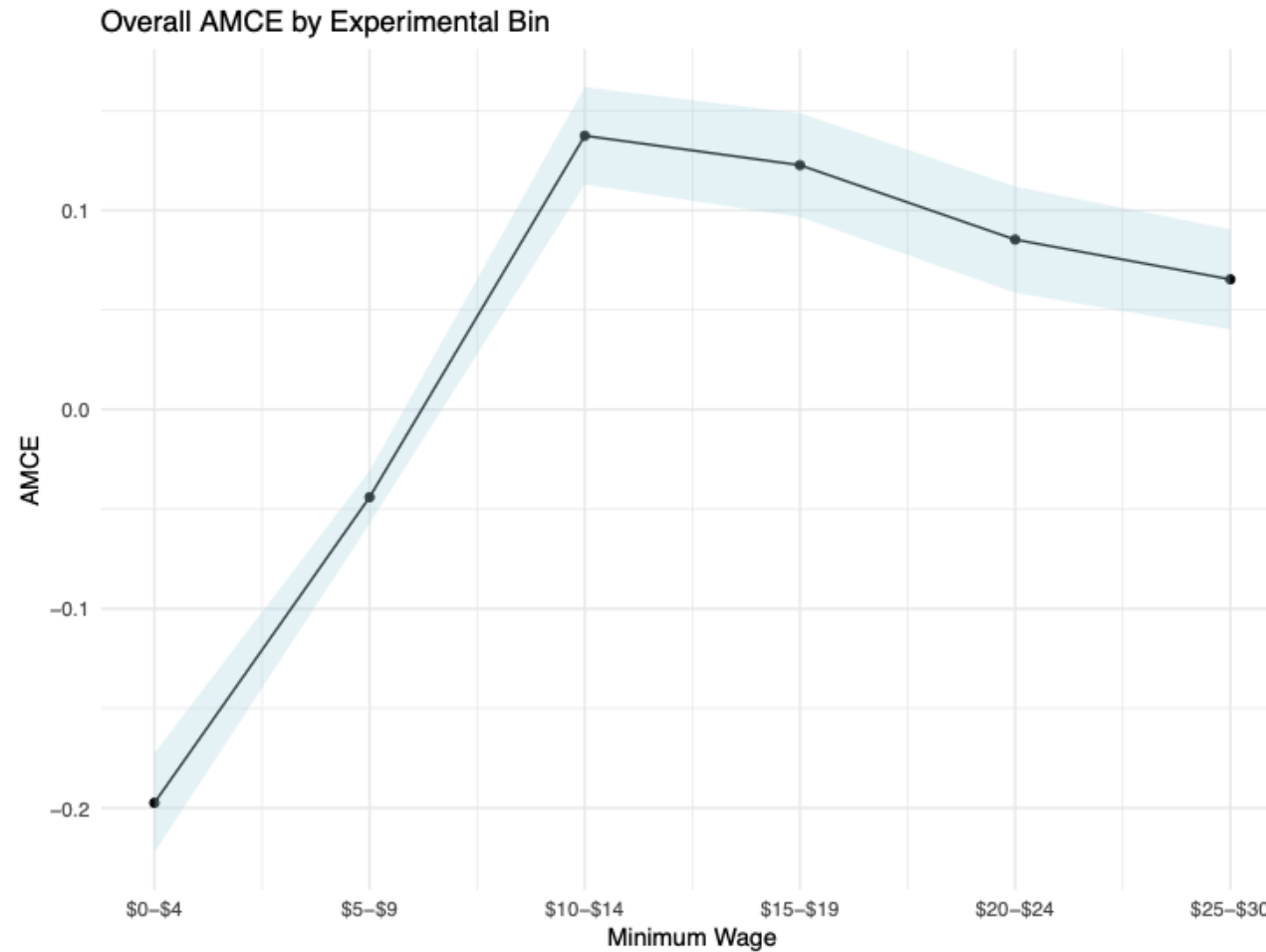
Question wording

- National: “In your view, what should be the federal minimum hourly wage?”
- Local: “In your view, what should be the minimum hourly wage in the town or city you currently live in, in dollars per hour?”

	DV: Minimum Wage		DV: Minimum Wage < \$7.25	
	All Obs	Obs ≤ \$50	All Obs	Obs ≤ \$50
Intercept	1,822.761 (1,174.215)	17.621*** (0.293)	0.046*** (0.009)	0.049*** (0.009)
Local Condition	−1,075.995 (1,657.287)	−0.560 (0.414)	0.016 (0.013)	0.017 (0.013)
Observations	1,253	1,196	1,253	1,196
R ²	0.0003	0.002	0.001	0.001

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Binned Approach



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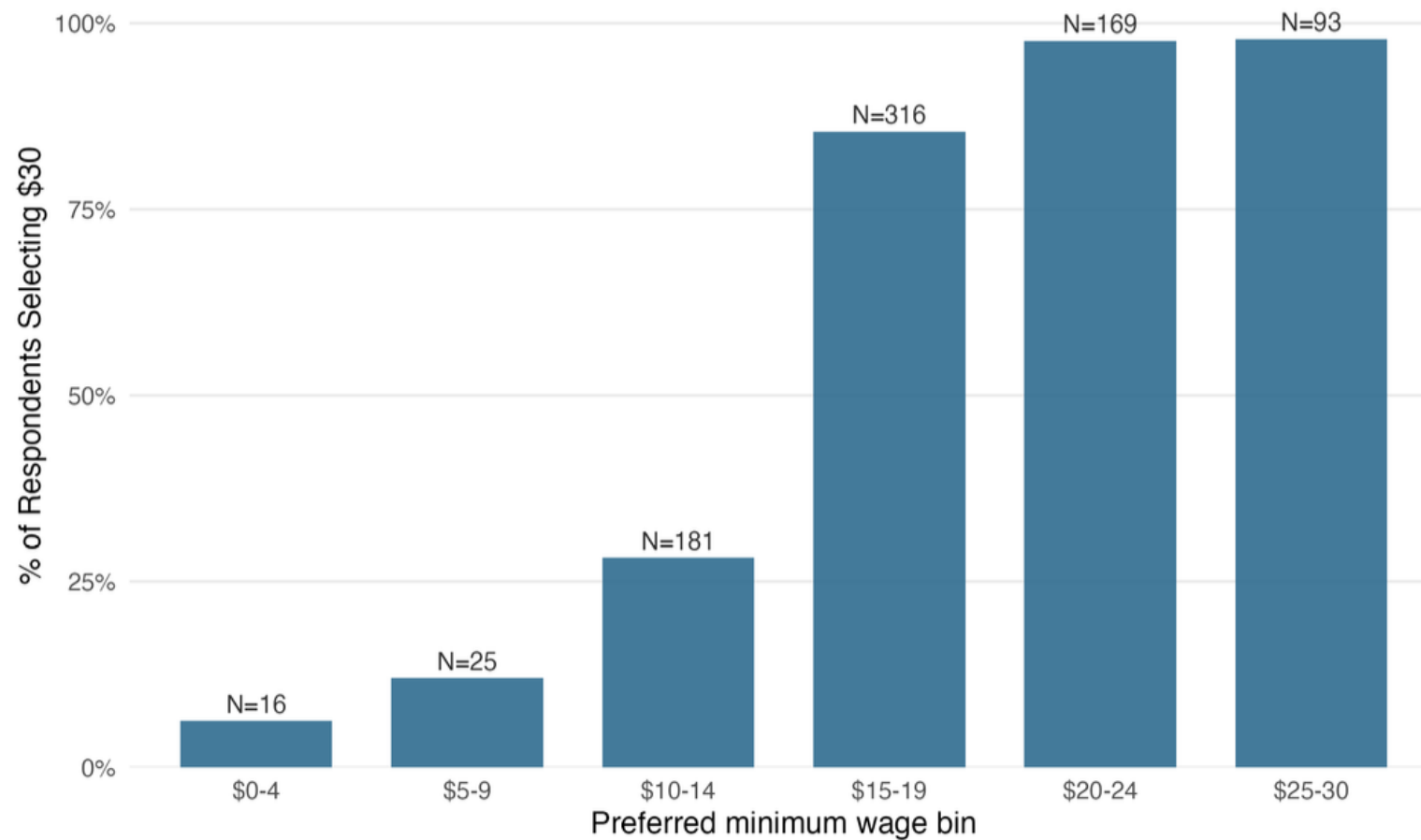


Figure A3: Percentage of respondents who select a \$30 minimum wage over a \$5 minimum wage in a direct comparison, broken down by respondents' ideal minimum wage.

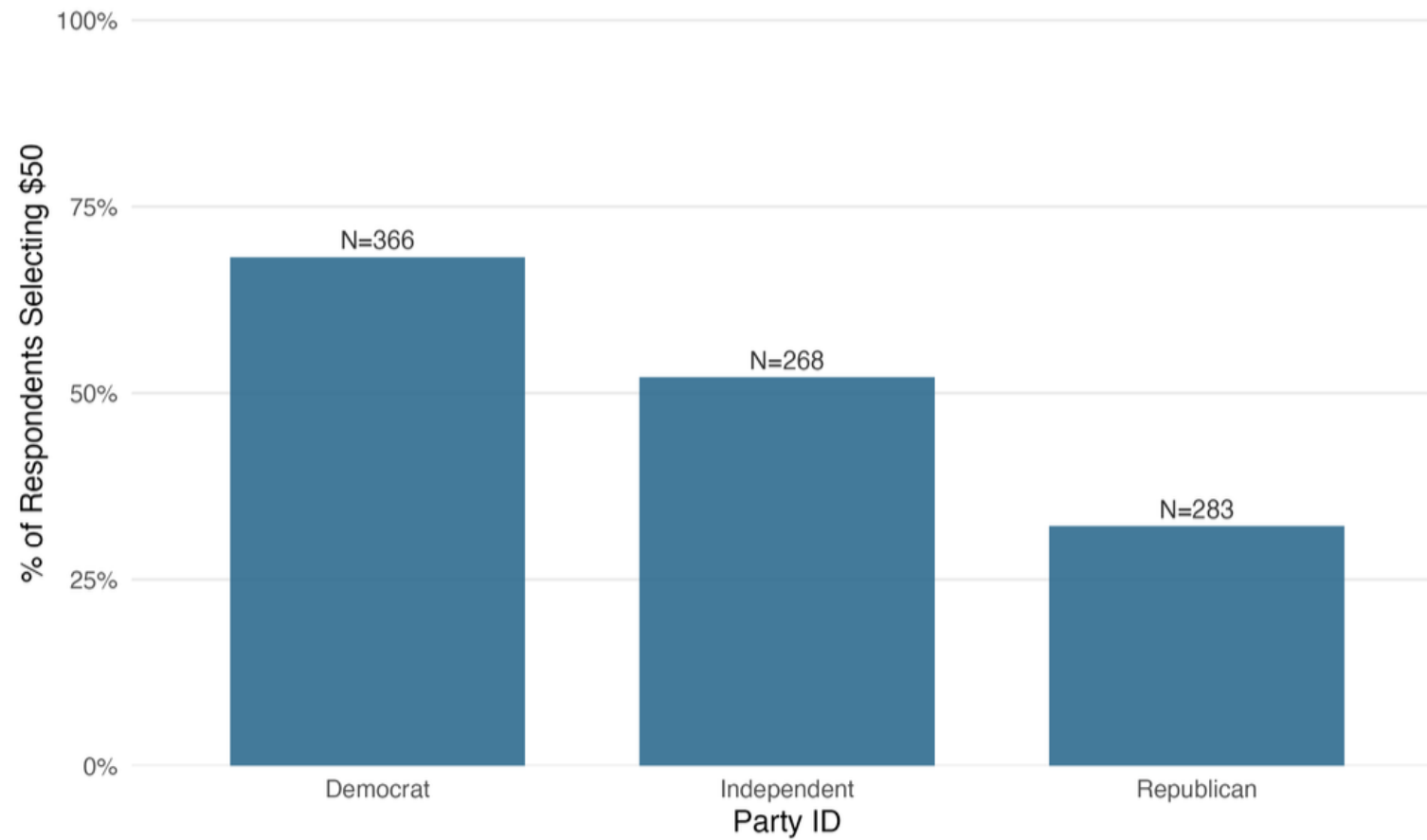


Figure A4: Percentage of respondents who select a \$50 minimum wage over eliminating the minimum wage in a direct comparison, broken down by respondents' partisan identification.

